

Born Sarup Kumari Nehru, **Vijaya Lakshmi Pandit** was the daughter of Motilal Nehru and Swarup Rani, and the sister of Jawaharlal. Like the rest of her family, Pandit was committed to the independence movement and social reform. The first Indian woman to hold a cabinet portfolio in British India in 1937, she presided over the All India Women's Conference, was a member of the Constituent Assembly and headed India's first delegation to the United Nations. Known for being intelligent, frank, friendly and well-spoken, she was India's first female ambassador to several nations, and the first woman to be elected president of the United Nations General Assembly (in 1953). One of the most well-respected diplomats of her era, she helped create crucial international support for India during its first few years as an independent nation.